

The plant collectors

MANY OF THE PLANTS that have become common in gardens all over the world are, in fact, very far from home. Most fuchsias, for example, come originally from South America, wisteria from China and Japan, many azaleas from the Himalayas in Asia, and tulips from western and central Asia. These are just some of the thousands of plants that have been carried across the world by plant collectors. Plant collecting had its heyday in the 19th and early 20th centuries, as intrepid botanists traveled farther and farther afield in search of unknown plants. Some collectors experienced great hardships on their voyages to distant places—they were shot at, caught in earthquakes, and attacked by wild animals. But despite all such adversities, the lure of making new discoveries spurred them on to explore some of the world's most remote and dangerous places.



A 19th-century plant collector with his collecting case, or vasculum



GOING EAST

The picture above shows botanists on a plant-collecting expedition to China in the 1920s. This region of the world has been of great interest to botanists for many years, and expeditions made there today still discover new plant species. The photograph on the right shows a botanist at work on a modern plant-collecting expedition.



FATHER AND SON

William Hooker (1785–1865) and his son Joseph (1817–1911) were both passionately interested in plants. William Hooker became the first director of The Royal Botanic Gardens at Kew in England. Joseph is especially remembered for collecting many species of rhododendron in the Himalayas.



Scutellaria tournefortia

This plant is named after its discoverer, Joseph Pitton de Tournefort

ROYAL MISSION

Joseph Pitton de Tournefort (1656–1708) was a botanist who was sent to the eastern Mediterranean by the French king Louis XIV. He returned with the specimens and seeds of over a thousand plants, many of which became garden favorites.

A 19th-century vasculum containing *Sarcococca hookeriana*, a species of sweet box

Sarcococca hookeriana is named after the Hookers

